

American bison

Bison bison



The American bison is an iconic species of the vast prairies that once stretched from the Rocky Mountains east across central North America, from southern Canada as far south as Texas. Also known as the American buffalo, this massively built animal has a large head, thick neck, and a prominent hump behind the shoulders. Its front-heavy appearance is enhanced by a long beard and a shaggy shawl of fur around the neck and forelegs. Full-grown males weigh 2,100–2,200 lb (950–1,000 kg), which is twice as heavy as females. Despite their huge bulk, bison can run at speeds of up to 35 mph (60 km/h). Both sexes have a pair of short, upturned horns.

Hunted almost to extinction

Bison used to live in huge, nomadic herds that roamed across long distances to graze. The population numbered many millions, with 30 million living on the Great Plains. They had long been hunted by Native American tribes, but during the 1800s, European settlers moved into the prairies and hunting for meat and hide accelerated. The bison's prairie habitat was converted to farmland, and by the 1880s, as few as 500–1,000 animals were left.

An end to hunting and the creation of national parks have raised the bison population to about 30,000 free-ranging animals, although the species only occupies less than one percent of its former range. There are about 500,000 domesticated bison on private ranches and

farms. However, the domesticated stock have been cross-bred with cattle and have lost many of their wild traits. Wild bison have excellent hearing and sense of smell, which are essential for detecting their chief natural predator, the gray wolf.

Follow the grass

Adult females and young live in groups of 10–60, led by an older cow. The bulls form separate herds or live alone. The breeding season is from July to September, when the bulls rejoin the female-led herds. The bulls fight for mating rights and dominance, clashing heads in spectacular battles. The females give birth to a single calf after a 10-month gestation, usually in April or May when there is a fresh growth of spring grass.

Bison have complex stomachs with four chambers to help them digest large quantities of grass, and they spend long periods chewing the cud. They can paw aside snow to reveal grass below, but in harsh winters, they migrate to lower, snow-free areas.

Wood bison and wisent

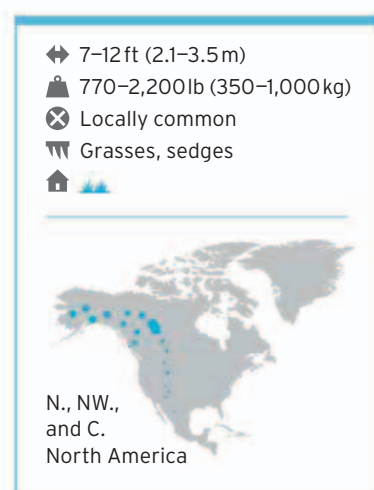
Some of the bison found in Canada are a separate subspecies known as wood bison (*B. bison athabasca*). The largest free-ranging herd of this species is found in Wood Buffalo National Park. There is also a population of wild bison in the Bialoweza Forest on the Poland-Belarus border, and these may belong to a second species called the European bison, or wisent (*B. bonasus*).

△ WINTER TRAVEL

The bison's thick coat and heavy mane protect them from the cold. They are so well insulated that even a dusting of snow on their back does not melt.

◁ YOUNG BISON

A calf can stand, walk, or run with its mother a couple of hours after it is born. The calves are weaned at about six months.



An adult American bison could leap over an adult human